



Cover story

WINNING IN Kashmir

ISSUE
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India needs to tackle the Valley's discontent by deciding how much autonomy Kashmir requires and working a way out to negotiate with Pakistan



The turnout and verdict in Jammu and Kashmir's 2008 Assembly election indicates that the political culture of the state remains vibrant. It is significant that centrist and secular forces like the National Conference and the Congress party have formed a Government under staunchly pro-India Omar Abdullah, the son of the former chief minister Farooq Abdullah and the grandson of Sheikh Abdullah.

Jammu and Kashmir has been a major national headache, from the tribal invasion of 1948 to the state's legal accession to the Indian Union and the global power politics that turned it into disputed territory, to the undermining of the state's special powers. The problem has been exacerbated by Pakistani covert intervention which in the last two decades has involved sending in thousands of trained militants into the state. The campaign has involved acts of terrorism in other parts of India, including

bomb blasts, taking of hostages and an aircraft hijack.

The Jammu and Kashmir dispute is today seen as an identity issue. Pakistan has declared the state to be the "unfinished agenda of partition." In recent years, the Pakistanis have conveniently declared that they are for "self-determination" in the state. General Pervez Musharraf came up with his four-stage plan involving identifying sub-regions that needed resolution, demilitarisation, self-rule in identified regions and joint management mechanisms to oversee the process. This sounds reasonable in theory, but would be complicated in practice. The one reason for this is that India and Pakistan do not follow the same national ethos. India is a secular country. Things are, to put it mildly, not quite the same in Pakistan.

A large number of Kashmiris have taken up guns to fight for what they call "azadi". A negotiated settlement of the problem of the state is in keep-

ing with India's international and bilateral commitments. It represents India's position of strength and the inability of Pakistan to alter the situation by force. It is also a move towards a humanitarian solution of the problem. As for Pakistan, its position is not clear. First they wanted accession, then began to back a plebiscite and are now say that they merely provide diplomatic and political support for "azadi".

According to the January 6, 2004 agreement, Islamabad will not permit its territory, or territory under its control, to be used for acts of terrorism against India. In turn, New Delhi has agreed to undertake a diplomatic resolution of the issue through direct talks. Besides the official talks, New Delhi and Islamabad have undertaken a number of back-door negotiations through special representatives like Satinder Lambah and Tariq Aziz. Some proposals have been discussed through the device of non-papers. Others have been put in the public domain through the media. Musharraf was quite adept at this and sought to stretch the political envelope, but for his part Prime Minister Manmohan Singh has

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